Despite Singapore ruling out foul play, conspiracy theories continue. A second autopsy was done on Sept. 23, and the government formed a probe team that arrested Shyamkanu and Siddhartha for culpable homicide on Oct. 1

Police later arrested singer Amritprabha Mahanta (left) and band member Shekhar Jyoti Goswami (right) on Oct. 2 and Zubeen's cousin DSP Sandipan Garg (below) on Oct. 8. All were present on the yacht



Shekhar Jyoti had alleged Zubeen was poisoned by Shyamkanu and Siddhartha, turning the case into a murder probe. Later, Zubeen's two government-appointed security guards, Nandeswar Bora and Paresh Baishya, were arrested on Oct. 10 over suspicious bank transactions

Zubeen's wife, Garima Saikia Garg, initially defended Siddhartha, triggering a vicious social-media backlash accusing her of an affair with him. She later reversed her stance, alleging foul play. Though offered the autopsy report on Oct. 4, she refused to read it, saying she trusted the government



On October 13, Garima demanded justice within 10 days; CM Sarma has urged patience

"gross insensitivity" by allowing her fashion show in the Northeast Festival in Singapore, organised under her brand Golden Threads of Assam, to continue despite news of Zubeen's death. Riniki denied the allegation and filed a criminal defamation suit.

THE MIYA FACTOR

The Miya community, or Bengali-speaking Muslims of immigrant origin, are claiming Zubeen as a unifying cultural symbol. Sarma's popularity partly stems from his hardline stance on the Miyas, whom many indigenous Assamese view as a cultural and demographic threat. His critics now point to Zubeen's rejection of religion and caste. Sarma hit back, citing the singer's Shiva tattoo and a song about freeing Assam from illegal settlers. In an interview with INDIA TODAY in 2022, Zubeen had clearly said he disavowed religion and caste, but stood firmly against illegal immigration. This attempt to appropriate Zubeen's agnostic legacy is also a subtle challenge to Sarma's anti-immigration politics and eviction drives, particularly in Upper Assam, where Gaurav Gogoi's emergence threatens to wean Ahom support from the BJP. Given Miyas' traditional Congress allegiance, the two forces could pose a formidable challenge to the BJP in 2026.

When the accused, including Shyamkanu and Siddhartha, were moved to Baksa jail, mobs rioted, pelting stones and torching police vehicles. Two dozen people were injured, and several arrests followed, among them, two Miyas. Sarma portrayed the unrest as a Congress–Miya nexus. "If I resign today, 50 per cent of the protests will end. And if Gaurav Gogoi is made chief minister, the remaining 50 per cent will also stop," he declared. The genuine mourners—"fans who admired Zubeen while he was alive"—had been replaced, he said, by those who saw political opportunity in his death. To appropriate the protests, Sarma's BJP launched a statewide campaign from October 22-26, demanding "justice for Zubeen", ironically from its own government.

Zubeen's cremation ground at Sonapur near Guwahati has become a pilgrimage site, attracting massive crowds daily. As reports emerged of unruly behaviour and alcohol consumption, particularly at night, the government capped visiting hours at 6 am to 10 pm. Opposition figures and civil society groups interpreted the restrictions as attempts to control public mourning and evidence of the government's discomfort with spontaneous expressions of grief that could fuel anti-establishment sentiment. The visiting hours were extended by an hour.

POLITICS OF DISTRACTION

Sensing the outrage over Zubeen's death could cause electoral damage, the Sarma government has moved to redirect public attention with agendas critics call diversionary or polarising. On October 22, Sarma announced that the November assembly session would introduce "historic bills," including laws against 'love jihad' and polygamy. Congress leader Debabrata Saikia accused him of "trying to polarise voters after Zubeen Garg's death". Two days later, the cabinet decided to table the long-suppressed T.D. Tiwari Commission report on the 1983 Nellie massacre, in which over 2,000 Bengali Muslims were killed. Withheld for four decades, the report will be made public on November 25. "After Zubeen's death blunted his Hindu-Muslim narrative, he's reopening old wounds before elections," Saikia said.

Zubeen's death has become a mirror reflecting Assam's volatile intersection of emotion, identity and power. The hashtag campaigns, the continuing probes and the political manoeuvring indicate that this is far from over. The resolution of the political firestorm ignited by the tragedy may well determine who governs Assam after 2026. ■